

Writing the Intro, Background, & Empirical Strategy

ECON 692 – Applied Economics Seminar

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April 9, 2026

Today's Agenda

Time	Duration	Activity
4:35	10 min	Check-in: where are you on the draft?
4:45	25 min	Anatomy of intro, background, empirical strategy
5:10	10 min	Break
5:20	20 min	Good vs. bad examples
5:40	25 min	GitHub Pages: project sites & blogs
6:05	85 min	Work sprint
7:30	25 min	Peer feedback
7:55	20 min	Wrap-up & next steps

Check-in

Quick poll:

- Who has a complete results section?
- Who has started writing prose (intro, background, anything)?
- Who is doing a blog or website instead of a traditional paper?

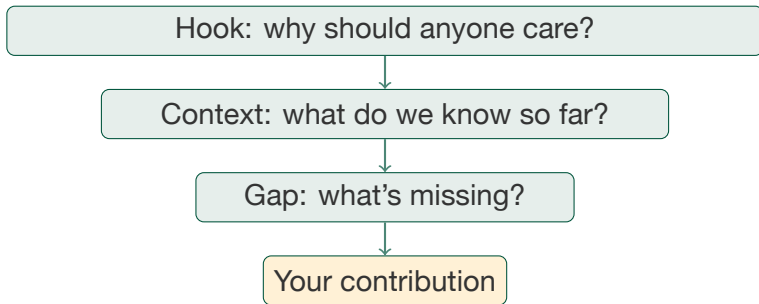
Full Draft is due April 24 — two weeks from today.

That means a complete paper (or complete site): intro, background, empirical strategy, results, conclusion. Today we focus on the front half.

Anatomy of the Intro

The Funnel Structure

Every good intro follows the same basic shape:



Your reader should know your research question by the end of paragraph one.

What Goes in Each Paragraph?

Paragraph 1: The Hook

- A fact, a puzzle, or a policy question
- Why this matters *now*
- Your research question (last sentence)

Paragraphs 2–3: Context

- What the literature says
- What gap remains

The Contribution Paragraph

- “This paper estimates...”
- What you do, what you find, why it matters
- One sentence per main result

The Roadmap (last paragraph)

- “Section 2 describes...”
- Keep it short — 3–4 sentences

Common Intro Mistakes

- **Too broad.** “Since the beginning of time, economies have...” No. Start with your specific topic.
- **Burying the contribution.** If your reader has to get to page 3 to find out what you did, you’ve lost them.
- **No stakes.** Why should I care? Connect your question to something concrete — a policy, a cost, a puzzle.
- **Mixing intro and lit review.** The intro should cite a few key papers. The deep survey goes in the background section.

Anatomy of the Background

What the Background Section Does

The background section has one job: **position your paper**.

It's not a summary of everything you've read. It's an argument for why your paper needs to exist.

Organize around three buckets:

1. **The phenomenon.** What do we know about the thing you're studying?
2. **The method.** What approaches have others used? What are the limitations?
3. **The gap.** What hasn't been done — and why does that matter?

Your lit review should end with a sentence that makes your paper feel *inevitable*.

Common Background Mistakes

- **The Wikipedia survey.** “Smith (2010) found X. Jones (2012) found Y. Lee (2015) found Z.” This isn’t a literature review; it’s a list.
- **No connection to your contribution.** Every paper you cite should be there for a reason. If you can’t explain why it’s relevant to *your* paper, cut it.
- **Too long.** Two to three pages is plenty for a capstone. You’re not writing a dissertation.
- **No synthesis.** Group papers by theme, not by author. What do they collectively tell us? Where do they collectively fall short?

Anatomy of the Empirical Strategy

The Empirical Strategy Recipe

This section should convince a skeptic that your approach is sound.

Four ingredients, in order:

1. **Data.** Unit of observation, time period, sample size, key variables. Where does it come from? What's excluded and why?
2. **Identification.** What variation are you exploiting? Why is it plausibly exogenous? What's the identifying assumption?
3. **Estimation.** The model. Write down the equation. Explain every term.
4. **Inference.** How are standard errors clustered? Why that level?

If you don't have an equation in this section, something is missing.

The Identification Argument

The identification argument is the heart of your empirical strategy. It answers: **why should I believe this is causal?**

For DiD:

- What's the treatment? When did it happen?
- Who's treated vs. control?
- Why is parallel trends plausible?
- What threatens it?

For IV:

- What's the instrument?
- Why is it relevant? (first stage)
- Why is it excludable?
- What would violate exclusion?

For every method: state the assumption, argue for it, and acknowledge what could go wrong.

Common Empirical Strategy Mistakes

- **No equation.** “I run a regression of Y on X with controls” isn’t enough. Write it out:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta D_{it} + X'_{it}\gamma + \mu_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}$$

- **Skipping the “why this works” argument.** Don’t just describe what you do. Explain *why* it gives you a credible estimate.
- **Mixing in results.** This section is about *design*, not findings. Save the coefficients for the results section.
- **No discussion of threats.** Every strategy has weaknesses. Name them. The reader will think of them anyway — better if you get there first.

Good vs. Bad Examples

Intro: Weak vs. Strong

Weak:

“Minimum wages have been debated for a long time. Many economists have studied this topic. Some find positive effects and some find negative effects. In this paper, I look at minimum wages and employment.”

Problems: no hook, no stakes, no specific question, vague contribution.

Strong:

“Twenty-three states raised their minimum wage in 2024, affecting over 8 million workers. Whether these increases reduce employment remains contested. I exploit the staggered timing of state-level increases to estimate the effect on teen employment using a stacked DiD design.”

Hook (fact), stakes (scale), question (implicit), method (clear).

Empirical Strategy: Weak vs. Strong

Weak:

“I use difference-in-differences. The treatment group is states that raised the minimum wage. The control group is states that didn’t. I control for GDP and population.”

No equation, no identifying assumption, no parallel trends discussion.

Strong:

“I estimate $Y_{st} = \beta D_{st} + X'_{st}\gamma + \mu_s + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{st}$, where D_{st} indicates state s raised its minimum wage by period t . Identification requires parallel employment trends absent the policy. I provide evidence in Section 5.”

Equation, named assumption, roadmap to evidence.

GitHub Pages

Not Writing a Traditional Paper?

Some of you are presenting your capstone as a blog post, a series of posts, or a website. That's great — the same principles apply to the writing itself.

You still need:

- A clear question and why it matters (your “intro”)
- Context on what others have found (your “background”)
- A transparent description of your method (your “empirical strategy”)
- Results with honest interpretation

The difference is the format, not the substance. Let's talk about how to set that up.

What Is GitHub Pages?

Free static website hosting, straight from a GitHub repo.

- Your repo already has code and data. GitHub Pages lets you add a website on top of it.
- URL: `yourusername.github.io/your-repo/`
- Supports HTML, Markdown, and — most usefully — Quarto.
- No server to manage. Push your files, the site updates.

Two Options

1. **Simple:** Write Markdown files, enable Pages, done.
2. **Polished:** Use Quarto to build a blog or multi-page site.

Option 1: Simple Markdown Site

If you just want a single-page write-up:

1. Create docs/index.md in your repo
2. Write your content in Markdown
3. **Settings** → **Pages** → source: main branch, /docs folder
4. Push. Your site is live.

```
your-repo/  
  docs/  
    index.md      # your write-up  
    figures/      # images for the site  
  code/  
    analysis.R
```

GitHub renders the Markdown as HTML automatically. No build step needed.

Option 2: Quarto Blog

For multiple posts, a polished layout, or interactive figures:

```
# Create a blog project
quarto create project blog my-capstone-blog

# Structure:
my-capstone-blog/
  _quarto.yml           # site config
  index.qmd             # landing page
  posts/
    01-question/
      index.qmd         # "Why I'm studying this"
    02-data/
      index.qmd         # "The data"
    03-results/
      index.qmd         # "What I found"
```

Run `quarto render` to build, then push the output to GitHub Pages.

Setting Up GitHub Pages

1. Go to your repo on GitHub
2. **Settings** → **Pages** (left sidebar)
3. Source: **Deploy from a branch**, branch: `main`, folder: `/docs`
4. Click **Save**

For Quarto: set the output directory in `_quarto.yml`:

```
project:  
  type: website  
  output-dir: docs
```

Then `quarto render && git add docs/ && git push`. Site updates in about a minute.

Work Sprint

Work Sprint (6:05–7:30)

Pick your track:

Paper Track

1. Write your intro (at least 2 paragraphs)
2. Write your empirical strategy section (at least 1 page)
3. If time: start the background

Website/Blog Track

1. Set up GitHub Pages on your repo
2. Create your first page or post
3. Write the “question and why it matters” section

I'll come around for check-ins. If you're stuck on how to start, try this: write the one-sentence version of your contribution, then expand outward.

Peer Feedback & Wrap-up

Peer Feedback (7:30–7:55)

Swap your intro (or first blog post) with a neighbor.

5 minutes: Read silently. Then answer:

1. Can you state their research question in one sentence?
2. Is the contribution clear — do you know what they did and what they found?
3. Where did you get confused or lose the thread?

If you can't answer #1 after reading the intro, that's the most useful feedback you can give.

Next Week & Deadlines

Next week (4/16): Figures, tables, slide design, and presentation prep.

Upcoming:

- Weekly progress report due **Wednesday**
- **Full Draft due April 24** (two weeks)

Between Now and the Full Draft

You need a complete paper or website: intro, background, empirical strategy, results, conclusion. Leave today with a drafted intro and empirical strategy, and you're in good shape.